



Making waves: Sonam, 19, was adjudged the 'Upcoming Player of the Tournament' in the Women's HIL after scoring four goals in three games, finishing as the highest-scoring Indian player. HOCKEYINDIA

be compromised to accommodate speed?

No, I don't agree. The Indians are faster. Not everyone, of course. But some of the players are faster than their European counterparts. Over the last seven years, we have become far better than most of the top five teams in terms of fitness.

The catch lies in decision-making. The Europeans take the right decisions because they have been subjected to such an environment right from their U-8, U-12, and U-13 days at their respective clubs.

We still believe in the *guru-shishya* combination: what the guru says, the shishya (student) has to follow. Coaching is not going to work like that. Coaching should be about the shishya asking questions of the guru. And the guru doesn't have to answer; he only has to ask the shishya to try and solve the problem. A guru should be a facilitator and not an executor. That's how you allow the player to be involved in the decision-making process. The philosophy has to change.

After the Pro League is over and before the LA Olympics, what are the intermediate targets that you have set for the team?

First, we need to put on a good show in the Pro League. If we finish somewhere in the top five, we will qualify for the World Cup. We'll get the ticket here itself, and there will be no pressure during the Asia Cup.

So that's an immediate target. A good performance in 2025 will lay the foundation for the 2026 World Cup and Asian Games. Playing in the World Cup semifinal should be a goal for our girls. By the end of February, I should have a core group of 24 players who I will be including in my World Cup plans.

role effectively.

We needed a leader in every area of the pitch. Navneet (Kaur) leads by example as a striker. Savita leads in defence. But we were missing a leader in midfield. Salima is the one who connects the midfield to both the strikers and defenders.

Who after Savita, the great wall of Indian hockey?

Old wine tastes better. Similarly, goalkeepers also mature later in their careers. Savita is at an age where she can offer more. If we are talking about a second line, the management, which includes me and my staff, has to develop that. It takes time.

If I start playing the second-line goalkeeper for a quarter in each Pro League game, she will also start

feeling, 'Okay, I am a part of this journey, I am a part of this team. That's why I am being given equal responsibility.' Bichu (Devi Kharibam), (Bansari) Solanki, and Madhuri (Kindo) need to compete for the two slots. In the Olympics and Asian Games teams, there is only one goalkeeper.

The competition for the goalkeeper position is tight because, in other departments, a midfielder can double up as a defender or a defender can play as a striker. But we have only one goalkeeper, and only the best gets that role. For now, Savita is one of the best in the business.

The foreigners have praised the stickwork of Indian women. Do you think a bit of the said skill can